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Lyft and China's Baidu look to bring robotaxis to Europe next year

Lyft's European expansion will include Chinese-made robotaxis.

The U.S. ride-hailing company announced Monday it has made a strategic partnership with Baidu to deploy the Chinese tech giant's Apollo Go autonomous vehicles across several European markets. The companies want to launch robotaxi services in Germany and the United Kingdom in 2026, pending regulatory approval.

If approved, Baidu's RT6 vehicles, which are equipped with its Apollo Go self-driving system, will be integrated into Lyft's ride-hailing app. Lyft CEO David Risher said the robotaxi service is an example of its "hybrid network approach, where AVs and human drivers work together to provide customer-obsessed options for riders."

Lyft has historically centered its ride-hailing business on the United States, while rival Uber has expanded globally and into other areas, like food delivery. But earlier this year, Lyft bought its way into the European market when it agreed to acquire the German multi-mobility app FREENOW from BMW and Mercedes-Benz Mobility for [about \\$197 million in cash](#).

The acquisition opened the European market to Lyft, which has only operated in the U.S. and Canada since it launched in 2012.

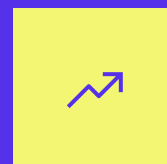
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Lyft and Uber, both of which sunsetted their own internal autonomous vehicle programs, are in a race to lock up partnerships with companies like Baidu, which have developed the technology.

Uber has partnered with more than 18 companies, covering the spectrum of how self-driving systems can be applied to the physical world, including [ride-hailing](#), delivery, and trucking. In this year alone, it has announced deals with Ann Arbor, Michigan-based May Mobility and [Volkswagen](#), as well as Chinese self-driving firms Momenta, [WeRide](#), and Baidu. Last month, Uber invested [hundreds of millions of dollars](#) into EV maker Lucid and autonomous vehicle technology startup Nuro in a bid to launch its own premium robotaxi service.

Lyft hasn't had the same pace of deals as Uber, but has made a few partnerships in the past year, including a plan to [add autonomous shuttles](#) made by Austrian manufacturer Benteler Group to its network in late 2026. Lyft has also said it plans to put [AVs from May Mobility](#) on its network in Atlanta later this year.

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Transportation Editor |

Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

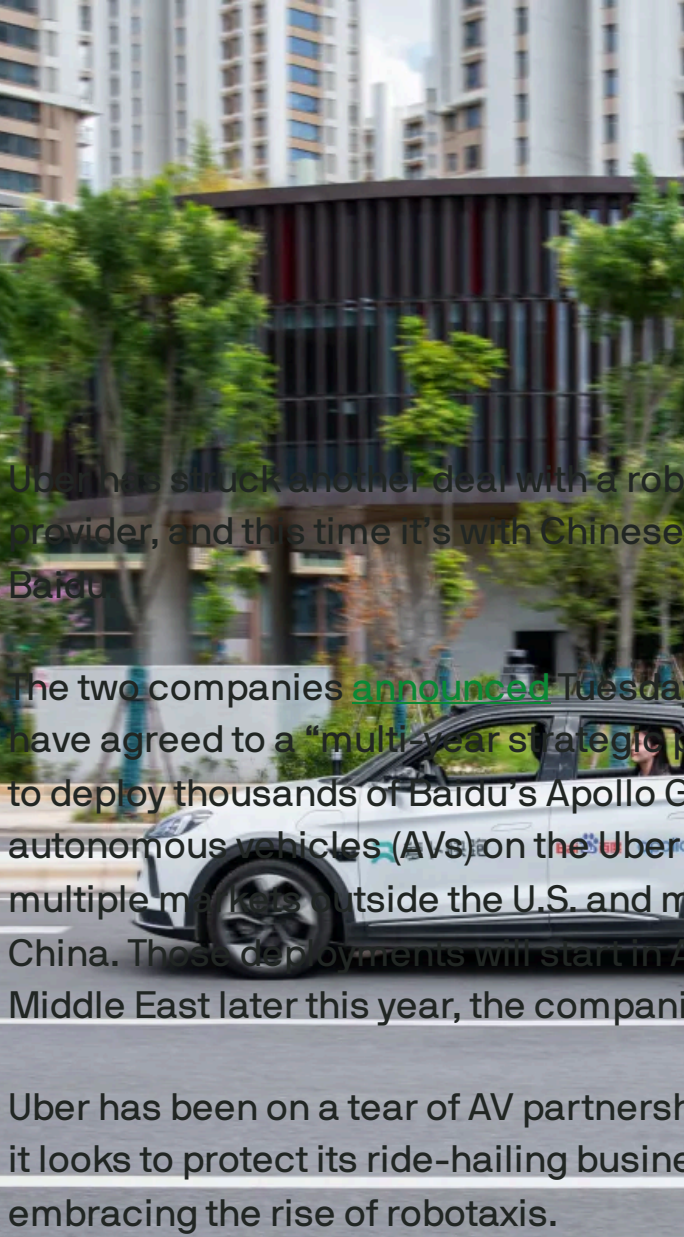
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Uber's latest robotaxi partner is China's Baidu



Uber has struck another deal with a robotaxi provider, and this time it's with Chinese tech giant Baidu.

The two companies **announced** Tuesday that they have agreed to a “multi-year strategic partnership to deploy thousands of Baidu’s Apollo Go autonomous vehicles (AVs) on the Uber platform” in multiple markets outside the U.S. and mainland China. Those deployments will start in Asia and the Middle East later this year, the companies said.

Uber has been on a tear of AV partnerships lately as it looks to protect its ride-hailing business by embracing the rise of robotaxis.

IMAGE CREDITS: BAIDU

In the last few months alone, Uber has agreed to put AVs from [Waymo](#), [Volkswagen](#), [May Mobility](#), and [Pony AI](#) on its platform in different cities around the world. In some cases, Uber is taking direct stakes in these companies. In May, Uber announced an expanded partnership with China’s WeRide that [included a \\$100 million investment](#). Uber is reportedly also considering helping its founder Travis Kalanick [finance a takeover of Pony AI](#).

As fast as these partnerships have been coming, they are still in the very early stages. In this instance, riders initially won’t be able to request a Baidu AV in Uber’s app. Instead, the companies say the rider “may be presented with the option” to have their trip fulfilled by a fully driverless Apollo Go AV. This is similar to how some of Uber’s other partnerships already work.

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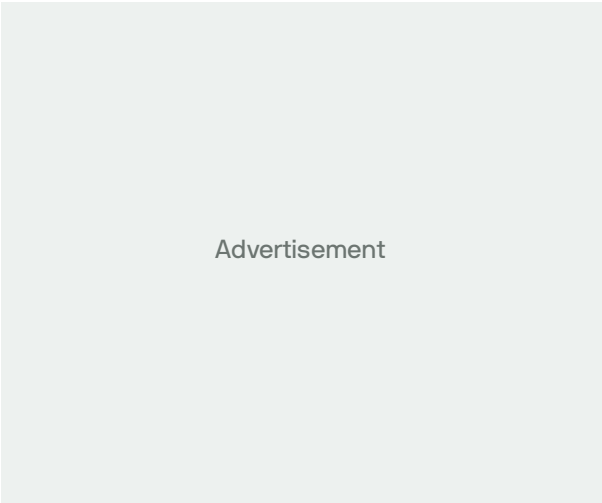
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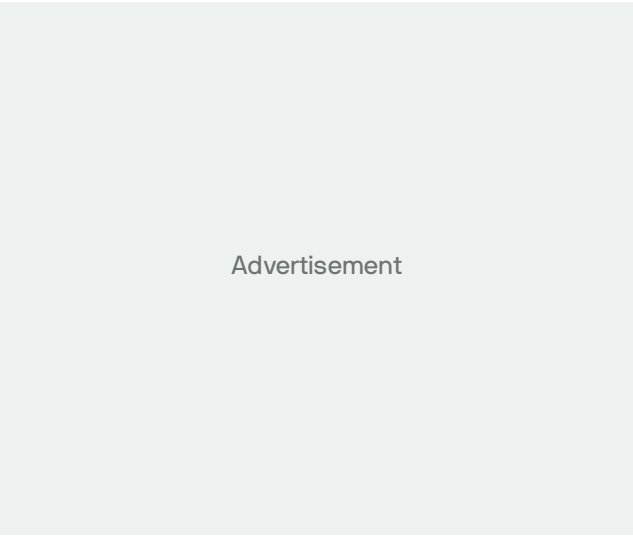
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Waymo rides cost more than Uber or Lyft — and people are paying anyway

Sean O'Kane — 5:00 AM PDT · June 12, 2025

The main premise of robotaxis is that high usage and lower labor costs will ultimately make it a cheap transportation option. That is still far from true, but now there's some data that gives us an idea of by how much.

Obi, an app that aggregates real-time pricing and pick-up times across multiple ride-hailing services, has just published what it's calling the [“first in-depth examination of Waymo’s pricing strategy.”](#)

IMAGE CREDITS: GETTY IMAGES

The company found Waymo’s self-driving car rides to be consistently more expensive than comparative offerings from Uber and Lyft — and it doesn’t seem to matter.

The report, shared exclusively with TechCrunch, is based on a month’s worth of data collected between March 25 and April 25 in San Francisco, California. Obi pulled nearly 90,000 “offer records” from Waymo, Lyft’s “standard” offering, and UberX in order to compare price and ETA. It then compared ride requests from the same times and routes. Obi found Lyft offered the lowest average price at \$14.44. Uber was next at \$15.58. Waymo’s average price across the month’s worth of data was \$20.43.

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Differences In Prices Between Waymo, Uber and Lyft
in Price per Kilometer

	Average Price	Standard Deviation	Median Price	Avg price/km
LYFT	\$14.44	\$1.92	\$14.22	\$7.99
UBER	\$15.58	\$2.22	\$15.36	\$8.36
WAYMO	\$20.43	\$3.65	\$19.52	\$11.22

IMAGE CREDITS: OBI

Ashwini Anburajan, Obi's chief revenue officer, told TechCrunch this was somewhat surprising given the early popularity of Waymo's service. Waymo said in May it's providing 250,000 [paid trips per week](#) across its first four cities. Higher pricing has apparently not dimmed that excitement.

"Colloquially, there is an idea that autonomous vehicles are something that will erode driver jobs and put drivers at risk. And I think the irony of what we've seen is that it's actually quite expensive to run an AV, and that that's not going to be happening, at least in the near term," she said.

At peak hours, Obi found Waymo's average price to be about \$11 more expensive than a Lyft and nearly \$9.50 pricier than an Uber.

"I didn't expect consumers being willing to pay up to \$10 more," Anburajan said. "I think [that] speaks to a real sense of excitement for technology, novelty, and a real preference to sometimes be in the car without a driver."



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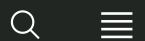
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Obi found that not only was Waymo more expensive, but there was greater variability in its pricing than with Uber or Lyft.

Anburajan said one explanation is that Waymo's pricing model is not as sophisticated. Uber and Lyft, she said, have had more than a decade to refine how they price rides. Those platforms are also a bit more dynamic, with drivers clocking in and out on their own time, or joining or abandoning the gig work altogether.

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lasting between 4.3 km and 9.3 km, a Lyft cost \$2.60 per km, an Uber cost \$2.90 per km, and a Waymo cost \$3.50 per km.

Price Per Kilometer by Provider

Price per kilometer is the highest for the first kilometer for any ride, but significantly higher for Waymo. **Rideshare companies factor in driving time to reach a consumer and bake the price of the distance traveled into the trip; consumers going longer distances will pay less per kilometer.** The price difference for Waymo compared to Uber and Lyft is 41.48% and 31.12% higher and on average the price of the rides \$5.99 higher for Uber and \$4.85 more expensive for Lyft.

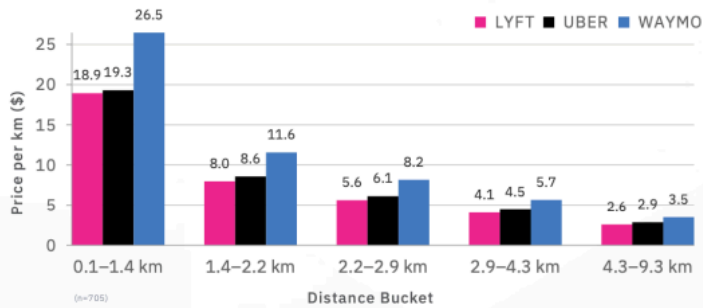


IMAGE CREDITS: OBI

The other impact is that longer wait times equals more expensive trips. After all, sending a car a long way to pick up a customer means it will perform fewer high-margin, short-distance rides.

That still isn't discouraging Waymo customers, Anburajan said, even though Obi found Waymo to have a higher variability in wait times.

In addition to the data-based deep dive, Obi also surveyed riders in Los Angeles, San Francisco, and Phoenix, Arizona to get a better understanding of what might be driving these trends.

The company found that 70% of users who had taken a Waymo ride said they preferred a driverless car to a traditional rideshare or taxi.

Despite that enthusiasm, Obi found that safety is still a big concern for riders. Of those surveyed, 74% said safety is their biggest concern about robotaxis. Nearly 70% of respondents said they think there should be some form of remote human monitoring of the rides (something that is already a common practice).

Perhaps even more striking is how people answered a question about whether they would be willing to pay more for a Waymo. Nearly 40% said

they'd pay "the same or less." But 16.3% said they'd pay less than \$5 more per ride. Another 10.1% said they'd pay up to \$5 more per ride. And 16.3% said they'd pay up to \$10 more per ride.

Anburajan said responses like those help further explain Waymo's pricier rides.

"There's something about being in the car alone" that is winning customers over, she said. "It is there for you to, like, kind of live in a little bubble and get from point A to point B, and be very comfortable doing so."

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Sean O'Kane

Sr. Reporter, Transportation | [X](#)

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If you're waiting for a self-driving car revolution, keep waiting

George Arison — 2:00 PM PDT · July 7, 2016

Not a week goes by, it seems, without some sort of development in the world regarding self-driving cars. Whether it's Google going on a [hiring spree](#) as it attempts to accelerate its efforts or General Motors [acquiring](#) Cruise, a driverless-car startup,

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the subject consistently finds a place in any given news cycle.

And now Uber [recently](#) got in the mix, putting autonomous cars on the streets of Pittsburgh.

But if you're waiting for a self-driving car revolution, you better keep waiting. Sure, the technology is there, but there are plenty of legal and regulatory battles that will have to take place before consumers are being zipped around in autonomous cars.

What's more interesting, and less talked about, is what a world of automated drivers will look like for some of the world's most disruptive transportation companies — Uber and Lyft — and how these ridesharing companies will become part of a one-sided, commodity marketplace model with complex logistics and low profit margins.

Lyft and Uber won the war over driver supply. And I should know; one of the companies that did not win on supply against them is Taxi Magic, a company I founded.

The phenomenal success of Lyft and Uber stems from the fact that they are two-sided marketplaces. Both have incredible network effects — more drivers attract more riders, which in turn attracts even more drivers. And this virtuous circle makes the economics of these two companies very different from others in the on-demand ground travel space.

But once fully self-driving cars are available for widespread use, one side of that marketplace will collapse. Drivers will be replaced with capital, and anyone with sufficient capital will be able to put a fleet of cars on the road. Car manufacturers, city governments, perhaps Google and Tesla and others

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will enter the game, massively increasing the supply of cars and flooding the market.



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With the advent of fully self-driving cars, it's easy to imagine rideshare companies looking more and more like the airline industry. And while some of us have brand loyalty (mostly because of mileage programs), the industry as a whole is fully commoditized and there is little difference between United and American. Airlines all do the same thing (move consumers from Point A to Point B), and primarily compete on pricing in a race to the bottom.

If this analysis is right, the industry of on-demand self-driving fleets will need apps that connect them to consumers, similar to [KAYAK](#) for airlines. This app could be Uber or Lyft, or both, but neither — as one-sided software layer connecting passengers to self-driving fleets — would be worth what they are worth now.

KAYAK is a very successful company used by millions to find air travel services, yet when Priceline bought KAYAK for [\\$1.8 billion](#) in 2012, KAYAK was [performing](#) 1.2 billion searches. That purchase price seems low given the quantity of searches, but it was an accurate reflection of the business' value. KAYAK is a one-sided marketplace generating revenue through lead gen to service providers (airlines and hotels). That type of one-sided marketplace is far less valuable than a two-sided marketplace that has a locked-up supply and also manages demand.

For technology geeks like me, self-driving cars are exciting — they will make commuting safer and our daily lives easier. But they also are a long way off, and before we get to use them, there is a lot more technology to create and, beyond that, policy and legal challenges to overcome. When they come into mass use, they are likely to be awesome, creating a new platform for future startups or alternative business models for existing businesses.

One thing self-driving cars won't do, however, is help Lyft and Uber (and other two-sided on-demand ground travel companies) maintain their existing business models or the valuations they command. While self-driving cars can help these companies create new platforms, it is hard to see how they can help them increase their value or justify valuations that these companies and their current business models now command.

As the age of the horse and buggy ended, jockeys faced a rough patch, but the age of the auto mechanic was on the horizon. This time around, we're going to see the end of driving as an occupation. And no one stands to lose more than ridesharing companies.



George Arison

Contributor | [X](#)

George Arison is the co-founder and CEO of online used car marketplace [Shift](#).

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